Emoji are gestures because internet - using corpus linguistics to analyze internet communication notes:

Writing is a technology that removes the body from language. Cultural notes about emojis are always changing, and how they fit into conversations. Internet linguistics like punctuations are varies every day and is vastly different from 100 years ago. Emblems are nonverbal signals with a verbal equivalent or direct verbal translation. They are deliberate movements of the body that are consciously sent and easily translated into speech, such as a wave that means “come here,” a thumbs-up gesture that means “okay,” and a wave that means “hello” or “good-bye.”

Emblems are easily identified because they’re frequently used in specific contexts. The person receiving the gesture immediately understands what it means. Emblem gestures have a very specific way of expression. The thumbs-up emoji may mean “good” in a culture and a vulgar emblem, an offensive gesture in another culture. There is a distinction in gestures that use conventional names vs those that do not. Emojis allow us to not feel disembodied in conversations online. We are allowed to gesture in texts through emojis. Non-emblem like gestures have a much wider room for interpretation.